D06 · Cold Chain & Specialized Logistics

03 · Oversize, project cargo & specialized equipment logistics

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1 WHAT IT IS

Project cargo covers oversize, overweight and high-value moves — industrial equipment, transformers, turbines, structures — that need route surveys, special permits, escorts, utility coordination and specialized equipment.

2 WHY IT MATTERS

In project cargo, the critical path is usually paperwork and planning, not driving. **Permits, route surveys and utility coordination take weeks; the move itself may take nights.** Projects that start transport planning late pay in demurrage, missed installation windows and penalties — costs that can exceed the freight many times over.

3 HOW IT IS DONE

1. **Freeze dimensions and weight early.** Every permit and survey depends on them; changes restart the clock.
2. **Survey the real route.** Bridges, clearances, turning radii, gradients and seasonal restrictions, verified on the ground.
3. **Build the critical path backward.** From the required on-site date, with contingency for permits, weather and escorts.
4. **Use specialists with corridor experience.** Heavy-lift carriers that know the route and the authorities reduce both risk and lead time.

IN PRACTICE

Never skip the physical route survey for truly exceptional loads

Desktop tools miss temporary restrictions, new construction and local conditions.

Start the permit critical path as soon as dimensions and weight are known

Permit lead time is usually the longest item on the schedule.

Use specialized carriers that already own the corridor relationships

Their experience and existing authority relationships reduce both risk and cycle time.

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Illustrative case built from typical industry values — not data from a specific company.

Illustrative case — Industrial equipment move, 4.2 m wide × 5.1 m high, 68 tons — Required delivery to a plant in Guanajuato with a fixed shutdown window.

Activity	Planned Lead Time	Actual
Route survey	10 days	12 days (one bridge required reinforcement assessment)
SICT + state + municipal permits	18 days	23 days
Utility coordination (line lifting)	7 days	7 days
Execution window	3 nights	3 nights (completed inside shutdown)

Result: Because the critical path was started early and a specialized carrier with corridor experience was used, the load arrived inside the shutdown window. A competitor that started later missed their window and incurred significant demurrage and schedule penalties.

HOW IT IS MEASURED

Permit Cycle Time vs Plan

Actual calendar days to obtain all required permits versus the planned critical path

Benchmark: Track variance; chronic underestimation indicates process or carrier issues

On-Time Project Cargo Delivery %

(Project cargo moves delivered inside the agreed window / Total project cargo moves) × 100

Benchmark: >=95% for a mature process with adequate planning lead time

WHAT YOU WOULD USE

Project Cargo Planning

Specialized project cargo / heavy-lift planning tools — Used by heavy-lift carriers and project logistics providers for route analysis and permit tracking.

Project management + document control systems — Critical for managing the multi-party permit and coordination timeline.

4 SO WHAT

> **Start with permits and surveys, not with the truck.** Freeze specs early, verify the route physically, plan backward from the site date and hire carriers who already know the corridor.

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